

The Summer We Forgot

Chapter One: A Memory Rekindled

The train pulled into the station with a groan, and Alex stepped onto the platform, gripping their worn satchel. Grayridge hadn't changed much in the years since they'd last been here. The town still smelled of saltwater and wildflowers, the streets still lined with faded pastel houses and weathered storefronts. But Alex felt like a stranger.

Returning home had never been part of the plan, but when their mother called asking for help packing up the family house, Alex couldn't say no. Now, standing here, the weight of the past pressed down like the humid summer air.

The past they'd tried so hard to leave behind.

Alex headed for the taxi stand, nodding politely at the familiar faces of neighbors who recognized them immediately.

"You heading to the reunion?" the cab driver asked as Alex climbed into the back seat.

"Reunion?"

"Yeah, the high school thing. Everyone's going. Big deal in a small town, you know."

Alex's stomach twisted. A reunion meant Riley. A face they'd spent years trying not to think about.

"Doubt it," Alex murmured, staring out the window as the taxi pulled away.

Chapter Two: The Reunion

The community center buzzed with chatter and laughter, the kind of forced joy that came from a crowd pretending to be thrilled to see each other. Riley stood at the bar, sipping a glass of bourbon and watching it all from the sidelines.

“Not much of a social butterfly these days, huh?” Jenna teased, sliding up beside him.

Riley smirked. “Never was.”

She rolled her eyes. “Oh, please. You used to be the life of the party. What happened?”

Riley didn’t answer. What had happened was Alex. The summer that had started out perfect and ended with a silence that stretched for years. He didn’t know why he was even here tonight. Maybe a part of him hoped Alex wouldn’t show up so he could finally move on.

But then, the door opened, and Riley’s breath caught.

There Alex was, framed in the soft yellow glow of the entryway. They looked older, more serious, but still achingly familiar.

“Well,” Jenna said, smirking, “looks like your night just got more interesting.”

Chapter Three: The Sparks Return

Alex felt Riley's gaze as soon as they walked in. It was impossible to ignore, like an electric current pulling them toward him. They turned slowly, meeting his eyes across the room.

He hadn't changed much. His hair was shorter, his shoulders broader, but the way he leaned against the bar with that infuriating smirk—it was as if no time had passed.

"Alex," Riley drawled as they approached.

"Riley," Alex replied coolly, keeping their distance.

He crossed his arms, his smirk deepening. "Didn't think I'd see you here."

"I didn't plan on it."

Riley's smirk faltered, his eyes flickering with something Alex couldn't place. "Still sharp as ever," he muttered.

"And you're still charming as ever," Alex shot back, though the words lacked venom.

The silence between them was thick, the kind that held years of unsaid things. Around them, the hum of the reunion faded, and for a moment, it felt like it was just the two of them in the room.

Chapter Four: The Forgotten Summer

The beach was quiet that night, the waves lapping gently against the shore. Alex kicked off their shoes, letting the cool sand sink between their toes as they walked.

“You always liked this spot,” Riley’s voice came from behind.

Alex turned to see him standing a few feet away, his hands shoved into his pockets. “What are you doing here?”

“Couldn’t let you hog the view,” he said, a small smile tugging at his lips.

Alex sighed, looking back out at the water. “I didn’t come back to stir things up, Riley.”

“I know,” he said softly. “But seeing you again... it’s brought back a lot of memories.”

“Yeah,” Alex murmured. “Me too.”

They stood in silence for a while, the only sounds the waves and the occasional cry of a seagull.

Finally, Riley spoke. “I wrote you a letter, you know. After that summer.”

Alex turned to him, their brows furrowing. “What letter?”

“The one I gave to Jenna. I thought—I thought you didn’t care.”

Alex’s stomach dropped. “Riley, I never got a letter.”

Chapter Five: The Truth Comes Out

The next morning, Alex confronted Jenna at the diner.

“You had no right to decide for us,” Alex said, their voice low but furious.

Jenna looked genuinely remorseful. “I was trying to protect you both. You were so young, and I thought...”

“You thought wrong,” Alex snapped.

Jenna sighed. “I know. And I’m sorry, Alex. I really am. But I can’t undo what I did.”

Alex left the diner feeling raw, their emotions swirling. All this time, they’d blamed Riley. But now, they didn’t know what to think.

Chapter Six: Rewriting the Past

Over the next few days, Alex and Riley spent more time together, revisiting old haunts and piecing together what had been lost.

One evening, as they sat by a crackling bonfire, Riley turned to Alex. “Do you think we could’ve made it, back then?”

Alex hesitated, staring into the flames. “I don’t know. Maybe. But we’re not those kids anymore, Riley.”

“No,” he agreed. “We’re not.”

Chapter Seven: A New Beginning

Months later, Alex stood in front of their packed car, ready to leave Grayridge behind. Riley pulled up in his truck, smiling softly.

“Need a ride?” he asked.

Alex laughed, sliding into the passenger seat. As they drove away, Alex reached for Riley’s hand, their fingers intertwining.

The past was behind them, and the future stretched out like the open road.

THE END .